



Men show a markedly greater inclination with 41 per cent having watched porn films. Surprisingly, however, a significant percentage, 46 per cent, also say they would never watch a porn film with their partners. Never? Not even to see what it would be like?

To figure where this prudishness about pornography stems from, we need to further examine the word. It has its Latin roots in *porne*, prostitute, or harlot as mom's good old dictionary puts it. It is a reference to the depiction of prostitutes in written and other forms. But surely, this is not the reason for porn's disrespectability, for Indian history which is replete with such renderings, shows prostitutes in a very honourable light. There is the famous dancing girl of the Indus or sculptures, like the one at the Pampapati Temple at Hampi, of a woman trying to seduce by drawing attention to her vulva. Prostitutes were the heroines of plays and novels. And while the Devdasis were sacred, those who worked outside the temples, the *ganikas*, had a social standing like that of the Bollywood stars of today. They were wealthy, hobnobbed with the elite, donated to temples, moved around with an entourage of personal staff, and were adored by the public. If just the portrayal of prostitution or sex makes pornography socially deplorable, then we'd have to rebuff or destroy a good deal of Indian artefacts and literature.

The thing is, there is plenty not just from our past but also in the contemporary time that is pornographic and yet acceptable. My more up-to-date Webster's Dictionary defines pornography as "material that is intended to cause sexual excitement". When thus devoid of a moral sentencing, this definition of pornography permeates almost all aspects of the modern lifestyle—advertisements, movies, television programmes, among others. There is always that covert attempt to sex things up to whet the public appetite for the product being sold, perhaps coax a subconscious transference of the natural libido. We'd assume no man is foolish enough to think that a seductress draped over that overpriced snazzy car comes with the car. And none of those lustless liplocks that the Censor Board hacks away could

Have you ever watched a porn film with your partner, before or during sex?

YES 34

Male 41, Female 27

NO 43

Male 43, Female 44

Rest don't know/can't say. All figures in per cent.

Forty-six per cent men and 36 per cent women belonging to the age group of 35-40 have watched porn, the highest in any age bracket.

20

PER CENT WOMEN IN LUCKNOW WOULD LIKE TO WATCH PORN SHOWING VIOLENCE. IN LUDHIANA, 17 PER CENT MEN ENJOY WATCHING PORN INVOLVING ANIMAL SEX.